FEAT · ACADEMIC

Construct *Definition*

The reasoning we measure, and how.

Status Draft · v0.6 · Template v1.1

Date 2026-04-23

Core construct Ability to think, evaluate, and communicate ideas in academic contexts

Dimensions Task Achievement · Content Quality · Argumentation · Critical Thinking

0. At a Glance

Product	FEAT — Academic
Core construct	Measures the ability to think, evaluate, and communicate ideas in academic contexts.
Target users	Pre-sessional students and university applicants; admissions and pathway decisions.
Dimensions	Task Achievement · Content Quality · Argumentation · Critical Thinking
Primary use case	Pre-sessional placement and university admissions readiness; supplements or replaces language-based entry assessments such as IELTS.

1. Purpose

FEAT Academic measures whether a candidate is ready to engage with academic reasoning at university level. It is positioned as a pre-sessional and admissions-point assessment — sitting at entry to higher education, not during a course — and serves as a credible **supplement or alternative** to traditional language-based entry assessments such as IELTS, for decisions that hinge on academic readiness rather than general language proficiency.

Target users include:

- International students applying to pre-sessional programmes or direct-entry pathways
- University admissions offices needing evidence of reasoning capability, not just reading comprehension
- Foundation and pathway providers using the assessment as an entry or exit gate

Outcomes support pre-sessional placement decisions, university admissions decisions, and pathway certification. **Not used mid-course or formatively** — this is a point-of-decision assessment.

2. Core Construct

This assessment measures the ability to think, evaluate, and communicate ideas in academic contexts — engaging with a question, weighing evidence or perspectives, and constructing a defensible argument in writing.

Successful performance looks like: the candidate engages with the question as posed, works through the reasoning rather than restating a memorised opinion, constructs an argument that holds together, and communicates in academic register.

Failure (Not Yet Competent) looks like: treating an analytical task as an opinion prompt, producing generic or memorised content, failing to engage with counter-arguments, or writing that cannot hold an argument structurally.

This assessment assumes sufficient working proficiency in written English to express ideas clearly; language accuracy itself is not the primary construct being measured.

2a. Construct Boundaries

FEAT Academic deliberately does **not** measure:

- **Subject-matter knowledge.** Every task is self-contained. A candidate who happens to know the topic gets no advantage. This is the key IELTS differentiator.
- **General English language proficiency.** Use FEAT CEFR where language ability is the primary question. FEAT Academic assumes working academic English; it does not grade it.
- **Research skills** — citation, source evaluation at library level, literature review. These are taught on-course.
- **Discipline-specific capability** — readiness for engineering, medicine, or law in particular. The construct is generalised academic reasoning.
- **Spoken academic ability.**
- **PhD-level research readiness** — a separate construct (independent research capability) not covered here.

Boundaries exist to prevent misuse: a candidate scoring Distinction on FEAT Academic has demonstrated university-level reasoning, not that they will thrive in a specific discipline or institution.

3. Dimensions of Performance

Dimension	What it represents	Why it matters
Task Achievement	Does the response engage with the question as posed, or drift into adjacent opinion?	Academic tasks require close reading and precise response. Drift is the first failure mode.
Content Quality	The depth and usefulness of reasoning once the task has been engaged with.	Without substance, responses become empty opinion — a known pre-sessional failure pattern.
Argumentation	Is there discernible argument structure — claim, reasoning, qualification?	Academic discourse is defined by structured argument. A student who cannot build one will struggle at university.
Critical Thinking	Demonstrated through evaluating claims, weighing alternative perspectives, and forming a justified judgement.	The core academic skill. This is what separates candidates who can learn at university from those who cannot yet.

3a. The Product Twist

> ***FEAT Academic measures how you think, not what you've read.*** *Where IELTS and similar tests reward candidates who happen to know the topic, FEAT Academic deliberately strips that advantage out — every task is self-contained, so reasoning is the variable being assessed.*

4. Performance Levels (FEAT Scale)

Not Yet Competent

Treats the prompt as an opinion question. Presents a single perspective without weighing alternatives. Argument is absent, or collapses under its own weight. May use academic vocabulary without academic reasoning. Not yet ready for university-level study.

Competent

Engages with the actual question. Presents a reasoned argument with some evidence or logical support, and acknowledges at least one alternative perspective. May be uneven but holds together. Can cope with undergraduate demands, potentially with support.

Merit

Engages precisely with the task. Develops a clear argument with connected reasoning, considers counter-arguments genuinely rather than dismissively, and uses academic register fluently. Ready for mainstream university study.

Distinction

Reframes or refines the question itself. Develops a sophisticated argument that anticipates objections, draws fine distinctions between perspectives, and communicates with the control of someone who already thinks academically. Strong candidate for selective institutions or accelerated pathways.

Insufficient Evidence *(off-scale — not a level)*

The response does not contain enough relevant content to evaluate reasoning or argumentation. The assessment is flagged for review or re-attempt rather than scored. This outcome is distinct from Not Yet Competent: a candidate who refuses, misreads, or submits a memorised template has not produced evidence that the rubric can judge, and must not be penalised as if they had engaged and performed poorly.

5. Task Design Principles

Every task must:

- Be self-contained — all information needed to respond is in the task itself (the key IELTS differentiator)
- Require reasoning, not retrieval
- Require engagement with at least two perspectives, claims, or considerations
- Specify a clear academic register and audience
- Be answerable without prior subject knowledge

Every task must avoid:

- Topic dependency — rewarding candidates who happen to know the field
- Simple opinion prompts that invite monologue rather than argument ("What do you think about…?")
- Culturally specific scenarios that advantage one background
- Formulaic two-sided structures that have become gameable through pre-sessional coaching

6. Evidence Model

Conceptual layer — what is being measured and why. Scoring rules live in Section 7.

The candidate's written response is the sole source of evidence. The four dimensions are **not levels or grades**; they are **evidence signals**, each pointing to a different aspect of the response and together informing the final judgement.

DIMENSIONS AS EVIDENCE SIGNALS

Task Achievement EVIDENCE VALIDITY

Whether the response engages meaningfully with the task as posed. A valid response addresses the question directly and stays aligned to its intent. Failure here means no usable evidence has been produced.

Content Quality DEPTH OF EVIDENCE

The substance of the response once the task has been engaged with: relevance, development of ideas, and meaningful contribution.

Argumentation STRUCTURE OF EVIDENCE

Whether ideas are organised into a coherent line of reasoning: identifiable claims, supporting reasoning, logical progression.

Critical Thinking EVALUATION OF EVIDENCE

The sophistication of the reasoning: evaluating the strength of claims, considering and comparing alternative perspectives, reaching and justifying a conclusion.

TWO-STAGE LOGIC

Stage 1 — Validation. Task Achievement determines whether the response provides valid evidence at all. If it does not, the remaining dimensions are not evaluated.

Stage 2 — Quality evaluation. If the evidence is valid, Content Quality, Argumentation, and Critical Thinking are evaluated together to judge its depth, structure, and sophistication.

WHAT THE MODEL EXPLICITLY IGNORES

- Which position the candidate takes — the construct is the quality of reasoning, not the stance
- Prior topic knowledge, even where it would be relevant

- Minor language errors that don't impede the argument
- Length for its own sake

INSUFFICIENT EVIDENCE (OFF-SCALE OUTCOME)

A response that cannot be evaluated at all is recorded as **Insufficient Evidence** rather than scored against the scale (see also Section 4). This is distinct from Not Yet Competent: a candidate who refuses, misreads, or submits a memorised template has not produced evidence the rubric can judge, and must not be penalised as if they had engaged and performed poorly.

Insufficient Evidence applies when the response:

- Is too short to evaluate argument structure
- Simply restates the prompt without engaging
- Is off-topic
- Is a memorised template applied regardless of the question asked

> *Template-response detection is particularly important in Academic because formulaic pre-sessional coaching produces responses that look academic but contain no actual reasoning. These are flagged, not scored.*

Dimensions ≠ Levels. · **Dimensions = Evidence signals.** · **Outcome = Judgement of competence based on evidence.**

---

7. Outcome Determination

Operational layer — how evidence is classified into an overall competence band. Concepts live in Section 6.

The overall judgement is holistic, reflecting the pattern and consistency of evidence across dimensions. To ensure consistency across candidates and reliability across AI and human raters, this holistic judgement is **operationalised through the following decision rules**. The decision rules are the scoring contract: they do not replace the evidence model — they implement it.

Analytic scoring produces a 4-tier judgement per dimension (Not Yet Competent → Competent → Merit → Distinction). The overall level is then derived as follows.

DECISION RULE SUMMARY

Validity gate (applied first)

- Task Achievement must be met.
- If Task Achievement is Not Yet Competent → overall = **Not Yet Competent**. No further evaluation applied.

Competent

- Task Achievement met, and
- Competent+ in the majority of remaining dimensions.

Merit

- Competent+ in all dimensions, and
- Merit in at least two dimensions.

Distinction

- Merit+ in all dimensions, and
- Distinction in at least two dimensions, and
- **Critical Thinking must be Merit+** *(upper-tier gate — protects against polished-but-shallow responses reaching Distinction on structural strength alone).*

The full dimension profile is always preserved in reporting, so admissions officers see where strengths and weaknesses sit.

HANDLING CONFLICTING DIMENSION SCORES

Even with the rules above, divergent profiles carry signal. The following patterns trigger reviewer flags rather than automatic averaging:

- **Strong Content, weak Argumentation** → a "knowledgeable but unstructured" candidate. Common in candidates from content-heavy education systems.
- **Strong Argumentation, weak Content** → the classic template response. Flagged because it may indicate memorised framework rather than genuine reasoning.
- **Strong Critical Thinking, weak everything else** → unusual; usually a candidate who thinks well but writes poorly. May warrant accommodations or a follow-up task.
- **Significant divergence** in any direction (e.g. Distinction in one dimension, Not Yet in another) flags for reviewer attention rather than being averaged into a misleading middle score.

CONCEPTUAL POSITIONING

FEAT Academic separates conceptual design from scoring implementation. The evidence model (Section 6) defines **what is being measured and why**. The decision rules (above) define **how performance is classified consistently across candidates.** Both are required; neither replaces the other.

8. Task Types

The five task types cover the three elements of the Critical Thinking dimension (evaluating claims, weighing alternatives, forming judgement). Evaluation of Claims is split across two task types — Data Literacy and Argument Evaluation — because reading evidence critically and dissecting an argument are substantively different cognitive operations, and two tasks here improve reliability within that element. Interpretation & Evaluation is a hybrid task: it tests Content Quality (comprehension and re-expression) in combination with Critical Thinking (evaluation).

Task Type	What it tests	Example scenario
Data Literacy	All four dimensions, with Critical Thinking emphasis on **evaluating evidence**	A chart or dataset is presented with a conclusion drawn from it; the candidate evaluates what the evidence actually supports, identifying misleading elements, missing context, and unstated assumptions.
Argument Evaluation	All four dimensions, with Critical Thinking emphasis on **evaluating arguments**	An argument is presented with its supporting reasoning; the candidate assesses its strengths, weaknesses, and underlying logic — what works, what doesn't, and why.
Weighing Alternatives	All four dimensions, with Critical Thinking emphasis on **comparing perspectives**	Two or more positions on a situation are presented; the candidate analyses where they agree and differ, and weighs which reasoning is stronger and why.
Interpretation & Evaluation	Content Quality (comprehension + re-expression) combined with Critical Thinking (evaluation)	The candidate is given an idea or concept and asked to explain it in their own words, then evaluate its limitations, assumptions, or scope.
Justified Judgement	All four dimensions, with Critical Thinking emphasis on **forming and defending a position**	The candidate is asked to reach a judgement on an open question, anticipating counter-arguments and justifying the conclusion against alternatives.

COVERAGE OF THE CONSTRUCT

Construct element	Covered by
Evaluation of claims	Data Literacy, Argument Evaluation
Weighing alternatives	Weighing Alternatives
Forming justified judgement	Justified Judgement
Interpretation and re-expression (Content Quality)	Interpretation & Evaluation

TASK SEQUENCING AND SELECTION

The set moves from receptive evaluation (Data Literacy, Argument Evaluation) through comparison (Weighing Alternatives) and comprehension (Interpretation & Evaluation) to productive judgement (Justified Judgement) — a natural cognitive ladder from reading critically to writing with authority.

Assessments may deploy all five tasks, or a rotating subset (e.g. 3 of 5 per sitting). Rotation supports test security and reduces candidate burden while preserving construct coverage.

MINIMUM TASK REQUIREMENTS PER ASSESSMENT

Each assessment must include at least:

- One **Evaluation** task — Data Literacy *or* Argument Evaluation
- One **Weighing Alternatives** task
- One **Justified Judgement** task

Interpretation & Evaluation is optional in the minimum set but strongly recommended where the candidate's comprehension and re-expression capability is part of the decision being supported.

9. Validity & Reliability

WHY THESE TASKS MEASURE THE CONSTRUCT

Academic readiness is fundamentally about reasoning in writing. By stripping topic knowledge out of the task, FEAT Academic isolates reasoning as the variable being assessed — closer to the actual construct "can you think at university level" than a reading-comprehension paper that conflates English proficiency, topic knowledge, and exam technique.

HOW CONSISTENCY IS ENSURED

- Self-contained task design removes content-knowledge noise

- Dimension-specific rubrics applied to every response
- Template-response detection flags known pre-sessional gaming patterns
- Critical Thinking weighted for top tiers prevents candidates gaming their way to Distinction via argument structure alone

MAIN THREATS TO VALIDITY AND MITIGATIONS

- **Cultural argument conventions.** Candidates from different academic cultures may structure arguments differently. Mitigation: rubric focuses on the structural *presence* of argument, not discipline-specific conventions.
- **AI-assisted responses.** AI can produce plausible academic writing. Mitigation: proctoring where appropriate, task design that rewards in-context reasoning over generic essay structure.
- **Coaching resistance.** Traditional pre-sessional coaching focuses on topic memorisation and templated structures. FEAT Academic's self-contained design is deliberately resistant — this is a validity feature, not a threat.

10. Framework Alignment

FEAT Academic aligns with frameworks that emphasise reasoning, evaluation, and communication as core components of academic readiness.

- **UNESCO AI Competency Framework for Students (2024)** — particularly the critical thinking dimension, which emphasises evaluating information, recognising limitations, and making reasoned judgements.
- **21st century skills frameworks (OECD, World Economic Forum)** — which identify critical thinking, communication, and evaluation as essential capabilities for academic and professional success.

These frameworks define what academic capability includes. FEAT Academic measures whether that capability is actually demonstrated in performance.

FEAT Academic does **not** claim alignment with IELTS or other language proficiency tests. It is positioned as a different construct:

- Language tests measure how well a candidate can use English.
- FEAT Academic measures how effectively a candidate can interpret, evaluate, and construct ideas in writing.

The two are complementary, but not interchangeable.

11. Use Cases

WHERE IT IS USED

- University admissions pathway decisions
- Pre-sessional programme entry and exit gates
- Foundation programme progression decisions
- Pathway provider certification

DECISIONS THAT CAN BE MADE FROM RESULTS

- Direct entry to undergraduate study / needs pre-sessional / not yet ready
- Pre-sessional exit — ready for university / needs extension
- Pathway certification for partner institutions

DECISIONS THAT SHOULD NOT BE MADE FROM RESULTS

- **Mid-course progress or formative judgement** — this is a summative, point-of-decision assessment, not a learning tool
- **General English proficiency** — use FEAT CEFR
- **Subject-specific ability** — use a domain-relevant test for engineering, law, medicine, etc.
- **Grade prediction in a specific discipline**
- **PhD research readiness** — different construct